

Teaching and mentoring undergraduates is an incredible joy, but comes with the serious responsibility to continually learn and improve as a teacher. During my doctoral work, I chose to complete my university's [Certificate in College Teaching Preparation](#), and have sought out the workshops and resources at the teaching centers at my subsequent institutions. I use Backward Design¹ to structure my teaching around articulated learning goals. Thinking through these goals helps identify implicit skills, making it possible to address them explicitly. More generally, it helps me focus on the student experience, and thereby tailor the quantity and organization of activities to help them reach the learning goals.

One situation where I found Backward Design especially helpful was in developing a *Writing Systems of the World* course. As this was new both for me and for Boston College, I needed to define the overall learning goals, and from there the more concrete learning objectives. Reviewing these objectives, I thought of an appropriate final summative assessment: ask the students to design a new writing system for a language of their choice. Students could take this assignment in different directions according to their interests, but all would need to engage in the various topics of the course, and thereby demonstrate their learning. The rest of the course—readings, other assignments, and in-class activities—fell into place as necessary preparation for students to complete the final assignment. The course was not flawless, and improved the second time around, but this structure made it possible and generally effective.

Using Backward Design has also helped me identify areas where skills are required but not explicitly taught, sometimes called the “Hidden Curriculum.” I try to think through what a student will actually *do* in an activity, then figure out how they would have learned how to do those things. In some cases, this means offering explicit instruction on topics I might not have thought of before. For example, many students benefit from explicit training in discipline-specific reading skills, so I have developed lessons around how to read research articles in my field. These kinds of interventions benefit all students, but particularly those who face systemic barriers to success in college.

As another example, some of my courses require students to plot quantitative data and conduct statistical tests. The learning objective here is quantitative reasoning, not the use of particular tools. As such, I share with my students a set of simple R scripts in Google Colab (i.e. cloud-based Jupyter notebooks), which students can modify with little training and no coding background. I find that students rapidly learn to use these scripts and move on to sophisticated conversations about the data. Of course, should a student study R systematically in the future, the scripts can continue to serve as a resource for them.

A growing theme of my teaching is the gradual adoption of “alternative grading” practices. I co-led a faculty book group on *Grading for Growth*² at Carleton, and participated in a yearlong faculty cohort on alternative grading at Boston College. For me, this has meant focusing on aligning grades with course outcomes and working to orient a course's structure

¹ Wiggins, G. P., & McTighe, J. (2005). *Understanding by design*. (Second edition.). Association for Supervision and Curriculum Development.

² Clark, D., & Talbert, R. (2023). *Grading for growth: A guide to alternative grading practices that promote authentic learning and student engagement in higher education*. Taylor & Francis.

around “feedback loops”. One way I have manifested these principles in my courses has been to clearly and explicitly distinguish between formative and summative assessments. Formative assessments, which I often call “Practice: [topic area]” are only entered into a gradebook as complete/incomplete, and contribute modestly to the final course grade. Only summative assessments are graded on a scale with some form of rubric, often a [single-point rubric](#). My Spring 2025 *Historical Linguistics* course used a full implementation of standards-based grading; finding some success with this model, I look forward to iterating on this design in the future. At Carleton and at Boston College, I believe that alternative grading has helped students approach the course with a growth mindset and a healthy attitude toward grades, and has helped me identify priorities and build around them.

When feasible, I also strive to build in opportunities for students to exercise choice in their learning. Choosing what they learn can improve motivation by allowing students to work on topics that matter to them, which reflects the wide range of reasons why students might take a class in my field. More fundamentally, I find this is a way I can enact expressing respect for them. At the same time, freedom requires appropriate guidance and constraints. In my Spring 2024 *Language in the US* course, students wrote six short papers, each chosen from a list of possible formats, including responding to a scholarly article or interviewing someone about their linguistic biography. I was extremely impressed at what the students produced, and a colleague and I presented our respective experiments in assignment choice at a recent *Grading Conference*³. I later used a similar structure of scaffolded miniature experiments in *Linguistics & AI*.

Based on my experience teaching *Laboratory Phonology* and other project-based courses, I have become seriously interested in “Course-based Undergraduate Research Experiences” (CUREs). Research courses offer a number of benefits⁴, most importantly that they involve a larger number and broader range of students than other formats for undergraduate research. Unlike supervising research assistants in a lab—which is also valuable—the focus of a CURE is the education that comes about through research. My Carleton students more than rose to the occasion: we conducted a study which, except for a small sample size, would fit nicely at major research conferences. Indeed, a subset of them conducted a larger version of the study through Independent Research the next term, and we co-authored a submission that we presented at an Acoustical Society of America conference.

While I remain dedicated to the liberal-arts model of education, I am also aware of students’ career anxieties. I participated in a recent [conference](#) that largely focused on supporting career exploration and thinking in terms of transferable skills. More narrowly, I have found myself supporting students interested in speech pathology. At Boston College, I informally mentored several students applying for graduate study in this area, and upon a dean’s request, wrote a proposal for a new minor in Communication Sciences and Disorders using existing resources. Now at Missouri, I am daily surrounded by faculty and students in this field and am learning all I can. Though a smaller component of my teaching, I intend to continue finding ways to encourage and support students exploring this and other career paths.

³ Geissler, Christopher and Morgan Rood. 2024. [Student-directed learning through assignment choice in two linguistics courses](#). *The Grading Conference 2024*. Online.

⁴ Christina Bjorndahl, Christopher Geissler, Kristine Hildebrandt, Anya Hogoboom, Michal Temkin Martinez. 2026. Colloquium on Making Undergraduate Research Work: Creating Infrastructure and Scaffolding for Multiple Pedagogical Scenarios. Georgetown University Round Table in Linguistics (GURT) 2026: Futuring Linguistics. [abstracts](#)